



GREY BANNER ALERT



mainroads
WESTERN AUSTRALIA

SHW Serious Incident (SI) – Final Notice

Date of Incident:	23 March 2022	Time of Incident:	06:48am
Region / Directorate:	South-West Region	Main Roads or Contractor:	Contractor
EQSafe Event Type:	Injury/Illness	EQSafe Incident Number:	26381
Actual Consequence:	Insignificant	Potential Consequence:	Major

Incident Short Description:	The Driver of a Traffic Control Vehicle experienced a microsleep, resulting in the vehicle crossing the opposing lane and striking a tree.
------------------------------------	--

Executive Summary:

At approximately 06:48hrs on the 23 March 2022, a single driver occupant driving a Traffic Control vehicle (single cab utility), was travelling westbound at approximately 85-90km/h on Redgate Road near Witchcliffe, WA. The driver was travelling from a depot situated approximately 112km away in Bunbury, towards a vegetation site located on Caves Road. The Traffic Control company was directly engaged by the Contractor responsible for the vegetation site.

The driver reported experiencing a 'microsleep' which resulted in the vehicle crossing the opposing (eastbound) lane. After crossing the opposing lane, the vehicle travelled along the eastbound verge for approximately 30 metres. The driver awoke when impacting the verge and tried to correct the vehicle before striking a tree and coming to rest on the eastbound shoulder.

Upon impact the driver's side airbag was activated; after coming to rest the driver exited the vehicle. The driver reported initially experiencing shoulder discomfort, although following a medical assessment was cleared of any serious injury.

After a thorough investigation, it was identified the driver had taken two rest breaks during the trip from Bunbury and did not feel fatigued. The driver did however report experiencing a history of disrupted sleep (including the night prior) and advised they weren't aware of any common signs or symptoms of fatigue when driving. Organisational factors identified included long distances and hours required to travel to the site and no camping away option was provided by the vegetation Contractor.

It was determined the microsleep/fatigue incident was likely caused by combination of long work hours, and a lack of both quantity and quality of sleep. Suitable corrective actions and operational controls have been implemented to address root causes and minimise the risk of fatigue-related vehicle incidents.

Incident Photos:



Front view of damage to Traffic Control Vehicle



Vehicle travelling westbound, crossing to opposing (eastbound) lane.



Image showing projected path of vehicle off road



Internal view of ute showing airbag activation

Contributing Factors:

- Driver did not recognise they may have been fatigued nor aware of any common signs of fatigue when driving.
- Disrupted sleep patterns affecting quality and quantity of sleep; driver reported a history of frequently waking in the night (including the night prior).
- Long work hours and distances travelled with no option for camping away to mitigate risk.

Corrective Actions:

- Toolbox talk debrief regarding incident with emphasis on fatigue management, signs & symptoms of driver fatigue and controls/methods to mitigate fatigue risks.
- Worker(s) to undergo sleep study assessment and adhere to any required/recommended medical intervention.
- Contractor company to develop guidance materials & parameters for camping away from 'home base' and share with contractors.
- Fatigue management training to be delivered to contractor's drivers.



Critical Risk:

This serious potential incident aligns with the Main Roads Critical Risk Profile relating to **Vehicles and Driving.**

Distribution of Notice:

Main Roads Personnel and Contracting Organisations